CYBER SAFETY GUY

kik·

A PARENT'S PLAIN-ENGLISH GUIDE

Kik is a messaging app that allows users to chat using usernames rather than phone numbers. While Kik is now intended for adults aged 18+, parents may still encounter references to it because it was historically popular with teenagers. Understanding how it works helps families discuss online safety confidently.

18+
Minimum age for new accounts

UK AGE CHECKS
Age verification required for UK users

USERNAME-BASED
Users do not need to share a phone number

GROUP CHATS
Can include people you do not know

Sources: Kik Safety Centre, UK Online Safety compliance requirements

WHAT PARENTS NEED TO UNDERSTAND

1. **Messages aren't limited to friends**
   Users can receive messages from people they have never met.
2. **Usernames can create a false sense of privacy**
   Not sharing a phone number does not remove all risks.
3. **Most chats are harmless**
   The biggest concern is unwanted contact from strangers.

SAFETY FEATURES / SETTINGS

WHAT EXISTS	WHAT TO CHANGE
Block & Report Block unwanted users and report concerns.	Review privacy settings together
Chat Controls Manage conversations and contacts.	Block unknown contacts immediately
Privacy Options Limit unwanted interactions.	Check group memberships regularly
Group Management Leave or manage group chats.	Avoid usernames containing personal information

STEP-BY-STEP: USE KIK SAFELY

1. Review privacy settings together.
2. Use a username that reveals as little as possible.
3. Only chat with people you know offline.
4. Leave groups that feel uncomfortable.
5. Block and report unwanted messages.
6. Talk openly about online experiences.

THE RISKS WORTH KNOWING

- **Strangers Making Contact** — Some users actively seek conversations with young people.
- **Inappropriate Messages** — Unwanted content can sometimes appear.
- **Fake Profiles** — Not everyone online is who they claim to be.
- **Age Misrepresentation** — Some users may not be the age they claim.
- **Oversharing** — Personal information can spread quickly.
- **Scams** — Fraudulent links and requests do occur.



THE 10-MINUTE CONVERSATION



- What do you enjoy most about using Kik?
- Who do you usually chat with?
- How do you decide who to add?
- What would you do if a stranger messaged you?
- Do you know how to block someone?

TRUST OVER SURVEILLANCE

Open conversations build confidence. Children are more likely to ask for help when they know they won't get into trouble.

IF THINGS GO WRONG

STAY CALM & GATHER EVIDENCE

- Save screenshots.
- Record usernames.
- Stop replying if a conversation feels unsafe.

REPORT & SEEK HELP

- Use Kik's reporting tools.
- Block the user immediately.
- Speak to a trusted adult.
- Contact police if there is immediate risk.



NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE
0800 1111
childline.org.uk

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